MCP

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Declined

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By Mike Noland

(*MARY is sitting in an empty classroom studying, when suddenly OLIVE enters and drops her backpack on the floor.)*

OLIVE
I'm so sick of this. It happened again. Can you believe it?

MARY
(*She is still studying and doesn't even look up*)
MmmHmm.

OLIVE
This is the fifth time that my card has been declined. I needed that smoothie. The problem is that they charge way too much. What are they putting in those things, gold dust? I mean, come on it's basically just fruit and water and some kind of powder. Powder, really? How much could powder even cost? The whole thing is just a big racket. (*pauses*) Did you hear me?

MARY
Yeah, powder, wow…

OLIVE
You know I need my smoothie before classes start. How am I supposed to get thru the day without some protein, but come on, they're so expensive.

MARY
Yeah, expensive.

OLIVE
You aren't even listening to me. My best friend is ignoring me. Listen to me!

MARY
Listening, I am…

OLIVE
Fine, fine, I'll just die right here and you won't even notice. I hope my final death rattle isn't too loud for you. When I die I want you to sprinkle my ashes at the smoothie place because they're the ones that killed me. Wait, ashes… maybe that's what the powder really is. Ooh, gross. I'm never having another smoothie from there again. (*pauses*) What are you doing? Why aren't you listening to me? I'm spinning out and you're supposed to calm me down. Why aren't you calming me down?

MARY
I'm a little busy here. I have a huge test that I should have studied for last night and I didn't. Somebody started texting me at 9 and didn't stop until 11:30. Then I had to clean my room up or my dad would kill me, so I'm sorry I don't have time explain to you, yet again, why your card was declined. You can't buy stuff if you don't have any money! Now let me study.

(*OLIVE sits silently for a few seconds.)*

OLIVE
I didn't know it was 11:30, you should have said something.

MARY
I did, I said, "It's 11:30, I need to study".

OLIVE
But people say stuff like that all the time. I thought you just wanted to get off the phone.

MARY
I did, that's why I stopped responding, at 11:30.

OLIVE
Oh, good. I just thought you were mad at me or something. That makes me feel better. Do you feel better, cause I do.

MARY
Yeah, I feel great, now can I study?

OLIVE
Sure, but just tell me one thing, why does my card keep getting declined?

MARY
Are you serious? You don't have any money in your account and you don't have any money cause you spend your allowance in, like, two days and you don't have a job. So that's why your card is getting declined!

OLIVE
I've had jobs, I've had lots of jobs.

MARY
Exactly, you can't keep a job long enough to make any money. You quit over stupid stuff.

OLIVE

No I don’t. Name one reason I quit a job.

MARY
You quit that job at the mall after one day.

OLIVE
All I did was fold clothes the entire time, it was boring.

MARY
It was a clothing store, what did you think you were going to be doing, creating designs for next years’ Paris show?

OLIVE
Oh, that would be cool, why couldn’t I do something like that?

MARY
Because you don’t know anything about fashion design and you’re still in high school, do I need to go on?

OLIVE
Plus, I didn’t see any cute boys in there the whole day.

MARY
Because it was a girl’s clothing store, why would boys go in there?

OLIVE
To see me.

MARY

You're ridiculous. What about the church nursery? You only worked in there one Sunday, what was wrong with that?

OLIVE
It's nothing but babies plus…

MARY
Let me guess, no boys.

OLIVE
Exactly and they had a speaker on in there playing the sermon.

MARY
Well, it is church.

OLIVE
But if I wanted to hear the sermon, I would have sat in church.

MARY
But you always go to sleep when you sit in church.

OLIVE
I know, but I couldn't sleep in the nursery because the babies kept crying. That was not the place for me.

MARY
Your dad said he would pay you to help him.

OLIVE
Hahaha, yeah right. That would last about two seconds and then we would be screaming at each other like maniacs. I can barely stand to be in the same house with him. There isn't enough money in the world to

make me work with that man. And he only said that because my mom was in the room. He doesn't really want to work with me. He likes my little sister way better than me anyway.

MARY
That's not true… but your sister is much nicer to him than you are.

OLIVE
My sister is such a fake. She only acts nice to make me look bad.

MARY
Well, it's working.

OLIVE
You don't know what my dad is like when nobody's around. He's totally different. When you're there he is all nicey nicey but when you leave he turns into a real monster. I can't do or say anything right.

MARY
But I've seen you push his buttons too. Like when you wore that really short skirt to go to the movies the other night.

OLIVE
It wasn't that short, and besides I was just going out with you and Claire.

MARY
But what did you think he was going to do when he saw you in that, applaud?

OLIVE

Ok, ok, I might have done that just to make him mad, but he wouldn't let me dye my hair.

MARY
You wanted to dye it lime green with red polka dots. You would have looked like my aunts' jello salad she makes every Christmas. It tastes really good but it would make a lousy hair style.

OLIVE
It's survival of the fittest. Kill or be killed. He's not the boss of me.

MARY
He really sort of is, right now anyway. Plus he gives you allowance every week.

OLIVE
It's not enough for a young, fashionable girl like me. I have to eat, buy clothes and pay for my own entertainment. The point is, I could never work for my dad.

MARY
Fine, I get that but you need to work somewhere for more than a couple of days.

OLIVE
I worked at the waterpark for almost 2 weeks this past summer.

MARY
You called in sick after the first day and missed 3 days the next week. You also spent more on your swimsuits than you made working there.

OLIVE
But when I was there, I looked good. It was just too hot and the sun was always shining and the kids were always screaming and there was water everywhere.

MARY
Yeah, who would have thought all that would be happening at a water park? This leads me to my original conclusion, you have no money because you have no job. Yet you keep trying to spend it anyway. It's obvious you haven't quite gotten a grasp how your bank account works. When you want to buy something, there needs to be enough in there to cover it. Check your balance once in awhile.

OLIVE
I can't.

MARY
Let me guess, you keep forgetting the passcode. It's probably 1-2-3-4.

OLIVE
I don't have a passcode but that's a good one. Is that yours? Can I use it too?

MARY
No, that's not mine. What do you mean, you don't have a passcode. How do you check your balance without a passcode?

OLIVE
I don't have a passcode because my dad won't let me have access to the account. He's scared I could somehow see his stuff.

MARY

His stuff? What does that mean? Is he laundering money for a drug cartel or something?

OLIVE
Laundering, are you kidding? He can't even get his dirty clothes into the hamper. Mom says he couldn't find the washing machine with a GPS, a map and a seeing eye dog.

MARY
Not that kind of laundering, oh, never mind. So you can't see your account balance because your dad won't give you access, right?

OLIVE
Right.

MARY
And your allowance is basically gone by the time you get it.

OLIVE
Yep.

MARY
And yet you still keep trying to use your card.

OLIVE
What can I say, I'm an optimist.

MARY
Then you have to get a job you like and keep it, it's that simple.

OLIVE

I knew you could help me.

MARY
Help you? What do you mean? I'm not an employment agency, I can't get you a job. I'm just trying to pass my history test, so I can get into college, get a degree and get a real job.

OLIVE
Really, do you believe that or are you just going to college to get an M.R.S. degree? You know, marry some guy and then get the good house and raise the cute family.

MARY
Look around, do you see anyone going to the malt shop or wearing bobby socks?

OLIVE
Who's Bobby?

MARY
You know what I mean, this isn't the 1950's any more. I don't have to get married to be happy and fulfilled or even have a family.

OLIVE
You tell your parents that?

MARY
What, are you crazy? I'm too young to die. I want to go to college, have fun, learn some stuff and get on with my life. I'm so sick of high school. I think I have had senioritis since the second nine week of freshman year.
OLIVE

But what about all the friends you've made? Won't you miss them? What about me?

MARY
I can barely stand most of the people here. I know they are only tolerating me for the most part. Sure, you're my friend, but I'm just going to college. I'm not moving to Siberia. We can get together on weekends and you can come down to visit and spend the night. It will be great.

OLIVE
That would be, but how am I going to do this without any money? You gotta help me get a job.

MARY
Wow, you really brought that around full circle, didn't you?

OLIVE
I'm persistent, that's a good quality for a worker isn't it? Let's make a list of my qualities and then figure out what kind of job I would be good for.

MARY
I'm not going to get any studying done till I do this am I?

OLIVE
Nope

(*MARY takes out a blank sheet of paper from her notes*.)

MARY
First, you are an incredible pain in the butt.

OLIVE

Not so sure that would look great on an application.

MARY
Maybe not but it's true.

OLIVE
Be serious.

MARY
I am serious, you can be incredibly annoying. However, if we rephrase it...How about… "is very persistent."

OLIVE
Persistent is good, what else?

MARY
Spirited.

OLIVE
Spirited, that sounds nice, what about... good with people?

MARY
No, everybody puts that down.

OLIVE
But I am good with people, I'm a people person. Everybody likes me.

MARY
Not everybody.

OLIVE

Wait, who doesn't like me?

MARY
You not my favorite person right now.

OLIVE
You're just grumpy because you're sleep deprived.

MARY
Yeah, because of you.

OLIVE
No, it's because you procrastinated till the night before and you used texting me as an excuse not to study.

MARY
See this is why some people don't like you, cause once in awhile, you're right. Let's finish this list. Alright...you're considerate.

OLIVE
Oh, that's good. I really am. Like when that new boy came to school on crutches, I took his stuff to every class, helped him carry his tray in the lunchroom and offered to give him a ride to and from school.

MARY
As nice as that was, I think his girlfriend might have gotten a little upset especially since he didn't ask you to do any of that for him and you barely knew him.

OLIVE

Was she really his girlfriend? I never heard anybody confirm that. Plus, he was really cute. I was not trying to flirt with him or anything.

MARY
Of course not.

OLIVE
I was just being, considerate. If he fell in love with me because of my kindness and beauty, that would just be a bonus.

MARY
But he didn't.

OLIVE
His loss, back to the list. What are some other good things about me?

MARY
Well you can be very determined, like a dog with a bone, when you set your mind to something.

OLIVE
Hmm, not sure if that's a compliment or not. You kinda called me a dog.

MARY
No I didn't...well maybe I did but not a bad way.

OLIVE
I'm a dog in a good way, like good girl, sit, stay, don't pee on the carpet.

MARY

I just meant that when you want something, you will do whatever it takes to get it. That's a good thing.

OLIVE
Then I choose to take that as a compliment. Maybe that should be added to the list? My ability to put a positive spin on things. That has to be valuable to someone.

MARY
Look, I only have a few more minutes to study, is there anyway we could speed this up?

OLIVE
Maybe. You're 18, right?

MARY
You mean you can't remember my birthday? It was 3 months ago and you were at my party. But how does my age help you get a job?

OLIVE
You know all those words you were coming up with for the list? Since you're 18, you can use them to fill out a reference for me on this job application. (*Pulls an application out of her backpack and hands it to MARY.)*

MARY
What?! All this time you just wanted to use me as a reference for a job? Why didn't you say that in the beginning?

OLIVE
I wasn't sure you would do it.
MARY

So the whole “They declined my card” was just a line to get me to fill this out?

OLIVE
No, that’s true, I’m broke.

MARY
Hand it here! Where will you be working ever so briefly this time?

OLIVE
The yogurt place, that way I will be getting a discount!

MARY
Well, that’s good, because they are expensive.

OLIVE
I know, must be the powder.